ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS · INC-5120

Search indexer crashloop due to increased batch size

Sev3 Final · version 1

1 Incident overview

Incident ID	INC-5120
Severity	Sev3
Incident date	5 Nov
Incident commander	Arjun Mehta
Affected services	search-indexer, storefront search
Document status	Final
Version	1
Prepared by	Asha Rao
Date prepared	12 Nov 2026

2 Executive summary

A release increased the search-indexer batch size from 500 to 5000 documents without raising the memory limit, causing an OOMKilled crashloop that resulted in the storefront search returning no results. The incident was resolved by reverting the batch size to its previous value. Follow-up actions include adding an alert for indexer crashloops and blocking the alias flip if the new index document count is less than 90% of the old one.

3 Impact

Customers experienced no search results on the storefront, which directly affected their ability to discover products. This impact was classified as Sev3 and persisted for one hour and ten minutes, from 09:40 to 10:50 on 5 Nov. The affected services were the search-indexer and storefront search, with no data loss or exposure reported.

Customer impact	search returning nothing on the storefront
Scale of impact	*Not provided by the user (Asha Rao, 12 Nov 2026)*
Data loss or exposure	none
Duration	1 hour 10 minutes

4 Timeline

Milestone	Time as recorded	Time (UTC)
Incident start	5 Nov 09:40	5 Nov 09:40 UTC

Milestone	Time as recorded	Time (UTC)
Detected	5 Nov 10:05	5 Nov 10:05 UTC
Mitigated	5 Nov 10:20	5 Nov 10:20 UTC
Resolved	5 Nov 10:50	5 Nov 10:50 UTC

Times were recorded in UTC.

Time to detect: **25 minutes** Time to mitigate: **40 minutes** Time to resolve: **1 hour 10 minutes**

Detailed timeline

Time	UTC	Event	Source
5 Nov 09:30	5 Nov 09:30 UTC	arjun found the search-indexer had been crashlooping	arjun
5 Nov 09:40	5 Nov 09:40 UTC	customers started reporting search returning nothing on the storefront	customers
5 Nov 10:05	5 Nov 10:05 UTC	support escalated to us	support
5 Nov 10:20	5 Nov 10:20 UTC	arjun reverted the batch size, pods stable	arjun
5 Nov 10:50	5 Nov 10:50 UTC	reindex finished, search back to normal	—

5 Detection

The outage was not detected by automated monitoring systems because there were no alerts configured for indexer restarts or index document counts. Detection relied entirely on support receiving approximately 15 tickets before escalating the issue. This process resulted in a 25-minute detection lag between the incident start and the time it was identified.

How it was detected	support escalated after ~15 tickets
Monitoring gaps	no alert on indexer restarts or on index doc count

6 Response and resolution

The incident was mitigated at 10:20 on 5 November when the batch size was reverted, which stabilized the pods. The reindexing process completed by 10:50, restoring search functionality to normal. The total time to mitigate was 40 minutes, and the time to resolve was 1 hour and 10 minutes.

Mitigation steps	1. reverted the batch size 2. reindex finished, search back to normal
Fix applied	reverted the batch size
People and teams involved	• arjun • support

7 Root cause analysis

The root cause of the incident was the release that increased the search-indexer batch size from 500 to 5000 documents while the memory limit remained at 2Gi. This configuration change caused the indexer to exceed its

memory allocation, resulting in OOMKilled crashes and a subsequent crashlooping state since the 09:30 release.

Trigger	search-indexer crashlooping since the 09:30 release
Root cause	release bumped the indexer batch size from 500 to 5000 docs while memory limit stayed at 2Gi causing OOMKilled
Contributing factors	• batch size increased without adjusting memory limit • no alert on indexer restarts

8 Lessons learned

What went wrong

- search returning nothing on the storefront
- nobody got paged
- no alert on indexer restarts or on index doc count

9 Corrective and preventive actions

#	Action	Type	Owner	Due date	Ticket
1	add alert on indexer crashloop	Detective	arjun	—	—
2	block the alias flip if the new index doc count is < 90% of the old one	Preventive	Nisha Verma	4 December	—

10 Related documents

No similar past incidents were found in this tool's records.

11 Information gaps

The details below were asked for while preparing this document and were not provided.

Detail	Section	Status	Asked of	Date
Scale of impact	Impact	*Not provided by the user*	Asha Rao	12 Nov 2026
Incident date (year)	Incident overview	*Not provided by the user*	Asha Rao	12 Nov 2026

12 Revision history

Version	Date	Prepared by	Status
1	12 Nov 2026	Asha Rao	Approved by Asha Rao

> How this document was produced: the RCA Assistant extracted the facts from notes supplied by Asha Rao, checked each one against a quote from those notes, asked for missing details, and drafted the narrative sections using openai/gpt-oss-120b, openai/gpt-oss-20b, qwen/qwen3.8-27b via api.groq.com. Layout, durations and the gaps table are generated by code. It was approved by Asha Rao. Generated 12 Nov 2026 08:44.